

# 165 Apollos

*The eloquent teacher from Alexandria who was willing to learn, and who "watered" what Paul had planted.*

Apollos was a Jewish believer from Alexandria in Egypt, a gifted speaker who knew the Scriptures deeply. He arrived in Ephesus teaching boldly and accurately about Jesus, though he knew only the baptism of John. Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and explained the way of God more fully, and he accepted their teaching. He then went to Corinth, where he strengthened the believers and argued powerfully from Scripture that Jesus was the Christ. His gifts made him so popular that some Corinthians began to say, "I of Apollos." Paul answered that he and Apollos were only servants: one planted, one watered, but God gave the growth. Apollos is a picture of great gifts held with humility.

## At a glance

|               |                                                              |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Apollos, a Greek name                                        |
| Origin        | A Jew "born at Alexandria," in Egypt (Acts 18:24)            |
| Gifts         | "An eloquent man, and mighty in the scriptures" (Acts 18:24) |
| When          | c. AD 52 onward                                              |
| Key places    | Alexandria, Ephesus, Corinth in Achaia, probably Crete       |
| Key people    | Priscilla and Aquila, Paul, Titus                            |
| Main passages | Acts 18:24–19:1; 1 Corinthians 1–4                           |
| Also in       | 1 Corinthians 16:12; Titus 3:13                              |

*"I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase."*

1 Corinthians 3:6, KJV

# The life of Apollos

Dates are approximate (AD), during Paul's second and third journeys. Nothing is known of Apollos before Acts 18 or after Titus 3.

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|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Early life</b><br><i>Alexandria</i> | <div>●</div> <b>Trained in Scripture</b><br>Born a Jew in Alexandria, Apollos becomes an eloquent speaker and "mighty in the scriptures." He is instructed in the way of the Lord. <i>Acts 18:24-25</i>                                                               |
| <b>c. AD 52</b><br><i>Ephesus</i>      | <div>●</div> <b>Bold but incomplete</b><br>"Fervent in the spirit," he teaches accurately about Jesus in the synagogue, though he knows only the baptism of John. <i>Acts 18:25-26</i>                                                                                |
| <b>c. AD 52</b><br><i>Ephesus</i>      | <div>●</div> <b>Taught more perfectly</b><br>Priscilla and Aquila hear him, take him aside, and explain the way of God more fully. <i>Acts 18:26</i>                                                                                                                  |
| <b>c. AD 52-53</b><br><i>Corinth</i>   | <div>●</div> <b>Waters the church</b><br>With a letter of welcome from the believers in Ephesus, he crosses to Achaia. He greatly helps the believers and publicly shows from the Scriptures "that Jesus was Christ." <i>Acts 18:27-28; 19:1</i>                      |
| <b>c. AD 53-55</b><br><i>Ephesus</i>   | <div>●</div> <b>His name used for a faction</b><br>Some in Corinth claim, "I of Apollos." Paul, writing from Ephesus, calls Apollos a fellow servant. Apollos, apparently near Paul, is not willing to return to Corinth yet. <i>1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:4-9; 16:12</i> |
| <b>Later</b><br><i>Probably Crete</i>  | <div>●</div> <b>Still traveling</b><br>Paul asks Titus to help "Zenas the lawyer and Apollos" on their journey and see that they lack nothing. <i>Titus 3:13</i>                                                                                                      |

## Group notes

# Key activities

*Acts does not explain how Apollos could teach about Jesus while knowing only John's baptism. Compare the disciples Paul met at Ephesus soon after (Acts 19:1-7).*

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- 1 Mastered the Scriptures.** He was "mighty in the scriptures," well trained in the Old Testament. *Acts 18:24*

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  - 2 Taught boldly.** He "spake and taught diligently the things of the Lord" and spoke out in the synagogue. *Acts 18:25-26*

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  - 3 Received correction.** He accepted fuller teaching from Priscilla and Aquila. *Acts 18:26*

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  - 4 Strengthened believers.** In Achaia he "helped them much which had believed through grace." *Acts 18:27*

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  - 5 Argued in public.** He "mightily convinced the Jews, and that publicly," from the Scriptures. *Acts 18:28*

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  - 6 Built on Paul's work.** Paul describes their work as one task: he planted, Apollos watered, and God made it grow. *1 Corinthians 3:5-9*

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  - 7 Stayed away from Corinth for a time.** Paul urged him to go, but he was not willing then. Many think he wished to avoid feeding the divisions; the text does not say. *1 Corinthians 16:12*

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  - 8 Kept serving.** He was still traveling in ministry in Paul's later years. *Titus 3:13*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Apollos is not named in the Old Testament.

## Old Testament

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| Echo: <b>Ezra 7:6</b>      | "A ready scribe in the law of Moses"  |
| Echo: <b>Proverbs 27:6</b> | "Faithful are the wounds of a friend" |

## New Testament

|                                      |                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Acts 18:24–28</b>                 | Apollos in Ephesus and Achaia                                        |
| <b>Acts 19:1</b>                     | Paul returns "while Apollos was at Corinth"                          |
| <b>1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:4–6, 22</b> | Believers take sides; both are servants                              |
| <b>1 Corinthians 4:6; 16:12</b>      | Not "puffed up"; he declines to come for now                         |
| <b>Titus 3:13</b>                    | Sent on his way well supplied                                        |
| <b>Tradition</b>                     | Luther suggested he wrote Hebrews; its author is unnamed and debated |

### For discussion

- Observe:* What words does Luke use to describe Apollos in Acts 18:24–25?
- Understand:* Why did Paul insist that "God gave the increase" (1 Corinthians 3:6–7)?
- Apply:* Apollos accepted correction from two tentmakers. How do you respond when someone offers to teach you?
- Apply:* Have you compared church leaders or picked favorites? How could you thank God for each?